friendship for Asian resurgence. For another, Nehru also possibly thought that early recognition might enhance India's global stature and would be one way for India to demonstrate that it was not a junior partner to the Americans or the British. Nehru wrote to Patel conveying that 'it might be desirable for India to accord recognition earlier than some of the others . . . our advisors are of the opinion that it would be definitely harmful to recognize them after the Commonwealth countries have done so. It would mean that we have no policy of our own, but follow the dictates of others.' [15]

A foreign policy decision of this magnitude—recognizing the new government in China as well as the timing of such recognition—ought to have been the outcome of a more deliberative process within the government. The more so because substantive issues, including the northern boundary, were involved. However, the process of institutional consultation within the Government of India on matters of foreign policy was weak. Nehru's letter to Patel in early December 1949 showed this. Nehru wrote: 'If you like I shall put it before the Cabinet. But the date depends on so many factors that it will have to be left open. Most members of the Cabinet have hardly followed these intricate conversations and consultations. But as you are interested, I shall of course consult you before taking action.' [16] The discussion on when and how to recognize the new regime in China appears to have been confined to the tight circle of advisors around the Prime Minister and lacked wider political consultation.

How did the Chinese approach the question of diplomatic relations in general, and especially with India? The Chinese Communist leadership displayed little haste or anxiety on the matter of securing international recognition. In March 1949, when it became clear that their final victory would take place in a matter of months, Mao Zedong declared at the second plenary